

What the Ground? Teaches Us

Learning emerges through real conversations - on worksites, in community meetings, and in everyday informal spaces.

PBJT's learning emerges through real conversations - on worksites, in community meetings, and in everyday informal spaces. In one cluster, workers told us that "green jobs" meant little without wage security. In another village, sustainability investments improved waste management but quietly increased unpaid labour for women. These experiences expose the gap between intention and lived impact.

Our field insights centre on:

How workers define dignity in the midst of transition.

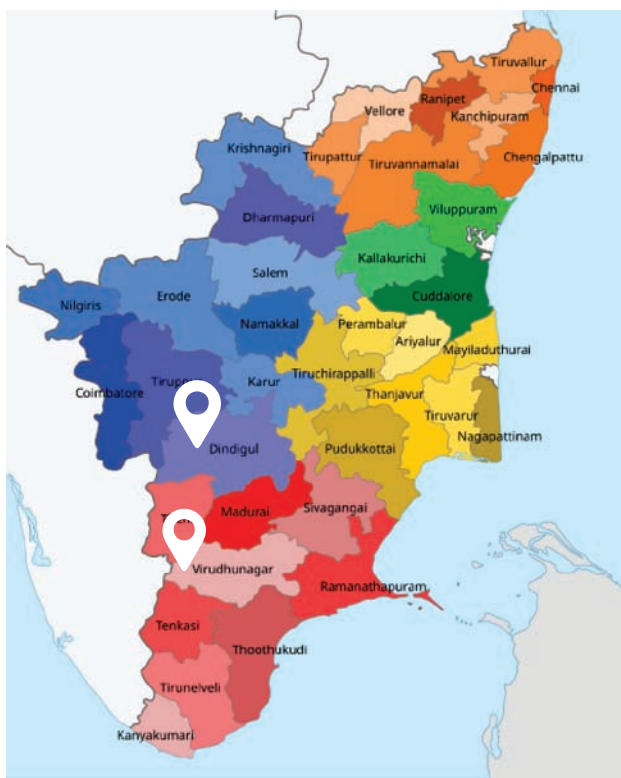
How communities negotiate responsibility with businesses.

How informal actors adapt sustainability simply to survive.



These are not polished success stories. They are honest, grounded accounts of transition - where power, vulnerability, and hope meet.

PBJT IN PRACTICE IN TAMIL NADU



DINDIGUL DISTRICT

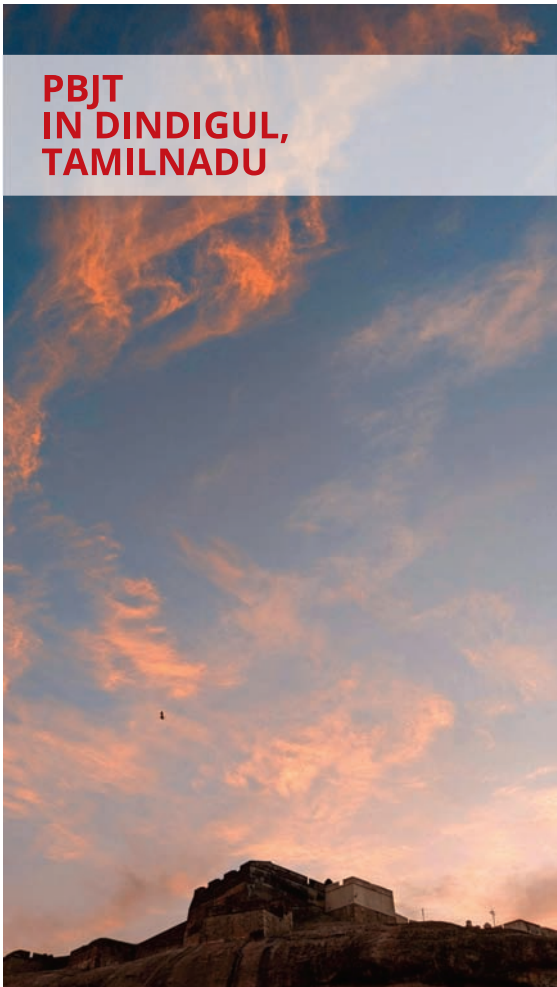
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VIRUDHUNAGAR DISTRICT



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HEAT AND RAIN FALL TABLE			
Year	Annual Rainfall (mm)1	Min Temperature (°C)	Max Temperature (°C)
2021	240.5 mm	19.5	37.5
2022	1303.6 mm	19.8	38.2
2023		19	38.7
2024		20	38
2025		19.1	39

Dindigul district, in the southern part of Tamil Nadu, sits at a unique ecological crossroads - where fertile plains meet the hill ecosystems of the Palani and Sirumalai ranges. These landscapes play a defining role in shaping the district's climate, water systems, and biodiversity. The plains experience a semi-arid tropical monsoon climate, while hill areas such as Kodaikanal enjoy a cooler, more temperate environment. With an average annual rainfall of around 836 mm, largely dependent on the North East Monsoon, both agriculture and water availability remain highly climate-sensitive. The district's varied soils—ranging from red loamy to black—support the cultivation of crops like onions, groundnuts, grapes, flowers, and vegetables. Nearly 70% of the population relies on agriculture and related activities for their livelihoods. Beyond farming, Dindigul has a strong base of traditional industries, including iron lock making, leather tanning, and textile production—especially the Art-Silk and Sungudi sarees of Chinnalapatti. Together, its natural resources, agrarian economy, and local industries shape the district's social and economic fabric.

PBJT in Five Villages across Dindigul

Village 1 – Avilipatti

GROUPS	MEMBERS
Gethu Group	13
Adolescent boys and Girls	27
MSME	1
Vendors Association	13

Activities	Total	Restored
Dump site	4	1
Water bodies	1	1
Tree planted	120	
Sanitation workers	Collected waste properly and received incentives from the Panchayat	

Village 2 – Pthampatty

GROUPS	MEMBERS
Gethu Group	13
Adolescent boys and Girls	25

Activities	Total	Restored
Dump site	2	1
Water bodies	2	0
Tree planted	50	
Petty shops	2 shops - Collecting empty milk packets and dosa batter packets	

Village 3 – Gopalpatty

Groups B	
Babers Association	13
Auto drivers association	11
MSME Group	4
Green workers	15

Activities	Total	Restored
Dump site	6	2
Water bodies	3	0
Solar	8	
Rain water	400	
Tree Plantation	100	
Waste recycle unit	1 -Run by the Panchayat	
Vendors commitment displayed on Zero usage of plastic	45	
Barber saloon	6 segregating waste and giving hair to process manure.	

Village 4 – Sanarpatty

Groups	MEMBERS
Babers Association	4
Environmental Protection Committee	70
MSME Group	3
Small vendors Association	27
Auto Drivers Association	19
Youth Groups	45
Adolescent Groups	28
Green gethu workers group	60

Activities	Total	Restored
Dump site	6	2
Water bodies	5	0
Solar	6	
Rain water	11	
Tree Plantation	200	
Waste recycle unit	1 -Run by the Panchayat	
Vendors commitment displayed on Zero usage of plastic	51	
Shops Best plastic free practices	Tea shop – 6 Chicken and Mutton shop - 2	

Dindigul PBJT & The Before and After Journey



Waste System Transformation

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DINDIGUL

The Before & After Journey!

Waste System Transformation

Before (June 2025)

- Waste dump sites were identified across villages.
- Mixed waste was disposed of without systematic segregation.
- Meetings were conducted with vendors and households.
- A community pledge was initiated towards waste segregation and responsible disposal.



Now (By February 2026)

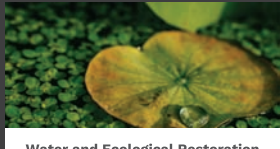
- Households are properly segregating milk packets and other plastic waste.
- Plastic waste is responsibly disposed of through structured collection systems.
- Hair waste from salons is being segregated and sent to farmers for use as organic manure.
- Community-level awareness has translated into consistent waste management practices.

Impact: Shift from informal dumping to structured segregation and resource recovery.



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The Before & After Journey!

Plastic Accountability Model

Before (June 2025)

- Plastics were indiscriminately dumped and burnt at local dump sites.
- Shops commonly used plastic covers for packaging.



Now (By February 2026)

- Plastics are now properly collected and sold to waste vendors for recycling.
- Shopkeepers have transitioned to eco-friendly alternatives such as banana leaves for packaging.
- Community-level conversations on plastic accountability are influencing local business practices.

Impact: Movement from open burning and pollution to circular waste management and responsible retail behavior



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The Before & After! *Journey!*

Water and Ecological Restoration

Before (June 2025)

- Waterbodies were identified during village mapping.
- Large quantities of village waste were dumped inside waterbodies and along bunds



Now (By February 2026)

- Waste from waterbodies and bund areas was cleared.
- Tree saplings were planted to restore and protect the ecological spaces.
- Community engagement has strengthened local stewardship over common water resources.

Impact: Transition from degradation of commons to ecological restoration and protection.



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The Before & After Journey!

Renewable Energy and Water Harvesting

Before (June 2025)

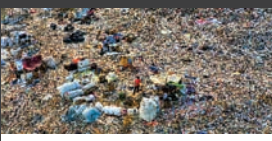
- Awareness discussions were conducted with villagers on rainwater harvesting and its benefits.



Now (By February 2026)

- A rainwater harvesting pit was successfully installed by a household.
- The intervention demonstrates a shift from awareness to adoption of sustainable water conservation practices.

Impact: Knowledge translated into household-level climate resilience action.



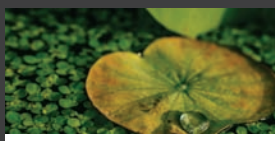
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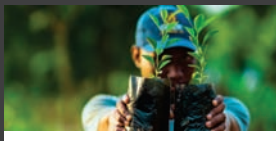
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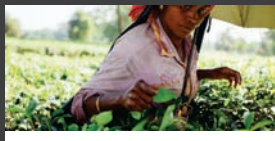
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The Before & After Journey!

Green Cultural Practices

Before (June 2025)

-- Festivals involved flex banners and conventional practices without sustainability considerations.



Now (By February 2026)

Green Festival Initiative (Sanarpatti Village)

The Sri Mettukaruppana Swami Temple Festival in Sanarpatti village (16 August 2025) was organized as a Green Festival with the support of Partners in Change (PiC).

Key sustainable actions included:

- Loudspeakers and lights were switched off for two hours to reduce noise pollution and energy consumption.
- A steel rack was arranged for collecting old clothes, encouraging reuse within the community. Sanitation workers received wages along with additional incentives in recognition of their work.
- Food was served on areca leaf trays instead of plastic plates.
- No plastic water bottles were used.
- For the first time, the administrative committee decided not to place flex banners.
- Nearly 80 kilograms of waste was collected, segregated, and handed over to the Panchayat.
- Seven saplings were planted post-celebration to mark the festival sustainably.

Impact: Cultural events transformed into platforms for environmental responsibility and community dignity.



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The Before & After Journey!

Responsible Business Norms

Before (June 2025)

- Vendors were identified and meetings were organized.
- Discussions were initiated on reducing plastic use and promoting silver vessels and cloth carry bags.



Now (By February 2026)

- Some vendors have committed to offering reduced prices to customers who bring their own vessels when purchasing meat.
- Increased awareness on reducing single-use plastics in local businesses.
- Dialogue between vendors and community members has strengthened accountability.

Impact: Emerging responsible business behavior rooted in local economic systems.



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Labour Dignity and Heat Response

Before (June 2025)

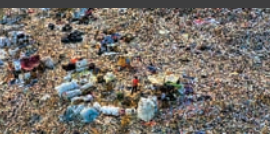
- As part of environmental awareness, World Environment Day was celebrated.
- An MSME distributed 100 saplings free of cost to villagers as a heat response initiative.



Now (By February 2026)

- Saplings have been planted across the village.
- Villagers are regularly maintaining the planted trees.

Impact: Community-led heat mitigation through greening and shared responsibility.



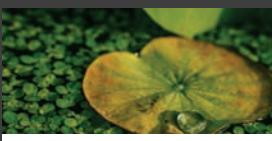
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The Before & After Journey!

Child Protection & Ethical Business

Before (June 2025)

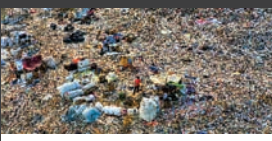
- A child marriage prevention rally was organized with the support of schools, colleges, and the Panchayat.
- Regular advocacy was conducted with stakeholders and vendors.



Now (By February 2026)

- Enterprises have committed to not involving children in their businesses.
- “No Child Labour” stickers have been displayed in business establishments.
- An official letter from the Block Development Officer (BDO) reinforced the directive against child labour.

Impact: Strengthened ethical business norms and institutional backing for child protection.



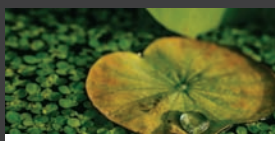
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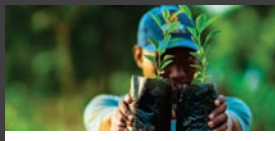
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What they

say?

VIDEOS



VIDEOS



IMPACT QUOTES AND PICTURES





No one-size-fits-all approach exists.

Just Transition often appears in global discussions as a policy framework for meeting climate goals, shifting energy systems, or channeling green investments – yet for workers and communities on the ground, it unfolds more intimately: in the quiet shifts to daily income, the strain on working conditions, the ebb and flow of access to essential resources, and the deeper sense of dignity that holds it all together – shaped always by local

A Place-Based Just Transition begins with a simple but critical question:
Who carries the cost of transition, and who decides how it happens?

Across most value chains, the heaviest burdens fall on those at the last tier informal workers, MSMEs, vendors, and marginalised communities. These are the places where environmental damage is felt first, livelihoods are most vulnerable, and transitions are often the most disruptive.
PBJT brings attention back to these actors and treats them as central, not peripheral, to sustainability.
Our thinking draws from global just transition frameworks developed by institutions such as the International Labour Organization and the UNFCCC, while grounding them in the lived realities of villages, peri-urban settlements, and local production clusters.
A transition is only just when it improves environmental outcomes and strengthens livelihoods, agency, and collective power.



A Place-Based Just Transition begins with a simple but critical question:
Who carries the cost of transition, and who decides how it happens?

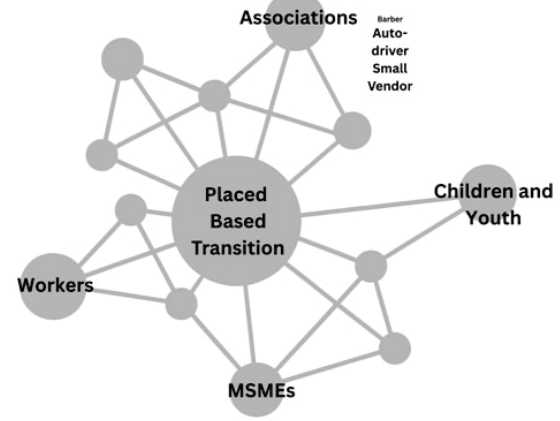


Place-Based Just Transition (PBJT) is an approach to sustainability that starts from the ground up.

PBJT recognises that environmental change and economic transition are not abstract ideas, they are lived every day in villages, neighbourhoods, worksites, and local production clusters.

PBJT focuses on how workers, MSMEs, vendors, informal labour, and communities experience climate action, sustainability policies, and business practices at the last tiers of the value chain. These are the places where risk concentrates and visibility is lowest.

A transition can only be called “green” when it also protects people. As workers often remind us, environmental improvements must go hand in hand with fair wages, safety, dignity, and secure livelihoods.



PBJT ensures that the shift to greener economies:

- Protects both people and the planet
- Strengthens local livelihoods rather than displacing them
- Makes businesses accountable to the places they operate in
- Builds resilient and responsible local economic ecosystems



Most sustainability efforts today stop at corporate offices or first-tier suppliers. But the real impacts of business; both positive and negative are felt much further down the chain.

Waste generated by brands is handled locally by sanitation workers and communities. Climate stress shows up first as heat, water scarcity, pollution, and unsafe working conditions. MSMEs and informal enterprises struggle to adopt sustainable practices because of limited access to finance, technology, and support. Workers experience the risks of transition long before companies or investors do. PBJT bridges this gap by shifting the focus of sustainability to where impacts are real, visible, and

PBJT as a Value Chain Discovery and Accountability Framework

Corporate sustainability reports speak of responsibility, ethics, and impact. PBJT asks a different question: how do these commitments translate in villages and worksites?

Using disclosures such as Business Responsibility and Sustainability Reports (BRSR), PBJT creates a ground-level lens for reflection:

- Do reported labour standards match worker experiences?
- Are environmental claims visible in local ecosystems?
- Are informal and last-tier risks acknowledged?

This work is not about auditing companies. It is about democratising sustainability language, enabling communities to understand what companies promise and to engage, negotiate, and seek accountability.

Our approach aligns with emerging global thinking on responsible value chains, including work by the Institute for Human Rights and Business and investor discussions that emphasise last-mile accountability.



Critical inputs in villages and production clusters

By working directly in villages and production clusters, PBJT helps businesses:

Identify informal workers, vendors, and micro-enterprises linked to their operations

Understand how environmental and social risks are distributed locally

Support MSMEs to transition responsibly

Build stronger, more ethical, and resilient supply chains

Accountability becomes real when it is visible at the place level—not just on paper.

PBJT - Framework

Principles

of Place-Based Just Transition

To Make Place-Based Transition actionable, PBJT develops and uses simple, practical tools that communities and practitioners can actually use.

These include: Value Chain Mapping Tools that identify informal and last-tier actors, Community Impact Reflection Guides to assess environmental and social change, Worker-Led Audit Formats that reflect lived labour conditions and Collective Dialogue Templates for grievance redressal and negotiation.

Each tool is designed to support discussion, not compliance. They help communities ask better questions, and help businesses see what is usually invisible.

Our approach prioritises strengthening existing



Embedded in Business Responsibility:

A just transition must be part of everyday business responsibility. All economic actors workers, vendors, MSMEs, and communities are part of the business ecosystem, not just large firms. Businesses have responsibilities toward the social and environmental wellbeing of the places they operate in. Transition efforts must strengthen existing livelihoods rather than displacing or marginalising them. Responsibility moves beyond compliance to active participation in community wellbeing.

Collectivisation and Collective Agency:

PBJT is built on collective strength. Transition processes are more democratic, inclusive, and sustainable when communities act together rather than as isolated individuals. Worker groups, community collectives, and local associations enable shared decision-making, collective bargaining, and problem-solving, reducing vulnerability and increasing agency.

Starting from the Last Tier:

PBJT prioritises those most affected - informal workers, small vendors, marginalised groups, and vulnerable communities.

Solutions are designed by starting with local realities, addressing unequal power relations, and strengthening community capacity to shape their own transition pathways.

Place-Based and Context-Driven:

Every place is different. PBJT is rooted in local social, economic, cultural, and environmental contexts.

Instead of one-size-fits-all solutions, PBJT builds on local knowledge, networks, and strengths to co-create relevant and dignified transition strategies.

Equity and Redistribution of Power:

A just transition requires shifting decision-making power toward those historically excluded. PBJT ensures meaningful participation of workers, women, informal sector actors, and marginalised communities in decisions that affect their livelihoods and environment.

Focus Areas:

Where PBJT works?

Strengthening Local Groups and Collectives

PBJT works through existing collectives worker groups, vendor associations, MSMEs, women's collectives and SHGs, youth and farmer groups, recognising them as the foundation of democratic participation and accountability.

Understanding Corporate Footprints on Local Lives:

We examine how business operations shape livelihoods, resource use, labour relations, informal economies, and everyday life along with consumption shifts within communities.

Brand-Level Value Chain Analysis:

PBJT looks beyond the final product to examine sourcing, production, labour practices, vendor relationships, and waste generation and disposal – revealing hidden actors and risks that are often excluded from sustainability narratives.

Corporate Accountability at the Village Level:

Accountability goes beyond compliance. It includes transparent engagement, grievance mechanisms, ethical sourcing, fair labour conditions, and continuous dialogue with local collectives.

Ground-Level Reflection on BRSR Disclosures:

Global markets, climate policies, and sustainability standards reshape local work and wages. PBJT anticipates these pressures while protecting local resilience. This perspective is increasingly recognised in global policy and investor discussions, including work by the Asia Investor Group on Climate Change on place-sensitive transition risks.



Methodology:

How?

PBJT works

PBJT follows a participatory action study approach that integrates social realities, environmental conditions, market systems, village governance, and business value chains. The focus is on strengthening existing groups rather than creating parallel structures, ensuring long-term ownership and sustainability.

Key elements include:

Supporting MSMEs to adopt green practices such as solarisation and waste reduction

Worker think tanks that define green job standards based on lived realities

Collective platforms that connect workers to green employment

Community task groups addressing waste, water, climate adaptation, and stewardship

A convener role that connects communities, businesses, institutions, and government schemes

Expected Change - Of Place-Based Just Transition

For Communities and Workers

Improved livelihoods, stronger collective power, increased participation in sustainability decisions, and access to green jobs.

For MSMEs

Support for sustainable production, access to finance and markets, and reduced transition risks.

For Businesses and Brands

Stronger value chains, improved ESG outcomes, deeper risk understanding, and more credible sustainability action.

For Local Ecosystems

Better environmental outcomes, stronger local governance, and more equitable economic systems.



PBJT: A New Architecture for Responsible Business

Place-Based Just Transition offers a model where sustainability is co-created by workers, communities, MSMEs, and businesses.

In this architecture:

- Local realities shape sustainability action
- Businesses become accountable to communities
- Workers become agents of transition
- MSMEs become sustainability partners
- Communities co-create their environmental and economic futures

This process does not aim to audit companies, but to democratise sustainability language. When communities understand what companies promise, they are better positioned to engage, negotiate, and hold systems accountable. Our work aligns with emerging global conversations on responsible value chains, including perspectives from organisations like the Institute for Human Rights and Business and investor-led frameworks that emphasise last-mile accountability.

